

John the Painter — A Telling

There is, or was, a pub called the Ship in Portsmouth, alongside the Hard. There are actually two old pubs called The Ship, more or less, down there to this day, so this story could well be about either of them, or both of them, or neither of them.

Sat in the corner, just round from the fire, you'd often see the figure of an old sailor: Tom was his name, Old Tom, a clay pipe in his mouth, a stoppered glass bottle peaking out of his coat pocket. At one time, he made what little cash he needed, selling fair winds to sailors bound for the East Indies, or the Americas, sailors fearful of not ever making it home again because they'd been becalmed. These were the days of sail, remember, so the sailors'd come and they'd purchase one of Tom's little stoppered bottles, and if the situation ever required it, they could pop the stopper out, and a fresh wind would blow, and they'd be on their way homeward again. But since Tom had caught the ghost, well, he didn't need to sell fair winds any more. Since he'd caught the ghost, he had all the pies he could eat and all the pints he could drink.

But before I tell you how that came about, I need to tell you about James Aitken, or John the Painter as he came to be known. The son of an Edinburgh blacksmith, his father's death meant he received a scholarship to a local school, and an apprenticeship with a local painter. But it was a far cry from the commission in the army he aspired to, so he made his way to London, where he partied and gambled away what little money he had. His short time as a highwaymen paid him quite well, but the gallows didn't appeal, so he tried America. Then came back, just as the American Revolutionary War began.

And now he was in Oxford, listening to the chat around him. The Navy's success was only partly due to the ships, and only partly due to the sailors. The *key* to its success was the dockyards. And if you take *those* out... Aitken felt a plan coming together.

He made his way to Paris and pitched his idea to an American delegate there. They weren't totally convinced, but they didn't say no. Which he took as a yes, and so he set off to Canterbury, where a tinsmith

made a rather clever contraption of Aitken's own devising, even if did say so himself. Mechanical magic. A slow burn incendiary device. Or as the tinsmith called it, a tin can without a base and some holes in the top.

Back to Portsmouth, and as is the way of even the *best* laid plans, they never quite work out the way you want them to. It was November: night came early, and work stopped early. John the Painter hid one of his tin cans in the hemp store, then made his way to the rope store, a huge brick building, over 350 yards long, just imagine that, a fifth of a mile. He tried to light a slow burn fuse, another invention of his own design, but it was damp. And it Just, Wouldn't, Light. And wouldn't you know it, when he tried to get out of the rope house, it had been locked up for the night.

He banged on door. Then he banged on the door and shouted. "'Scuse me.. Excuse me... Anyone there? ANYONE THERE?"

Eventually, a couple of men heard the banging, and let him out — "I'm sorry, I just wandered in, curious like, you know" - and they would remember seeing him, later, John the Painter, the Scottish chap, with the pale complexion and the strange fan tailed hat.

Back in his lodging room that night, he tried to perfect his slow burn fuse. Clouds of smoke everywhere. He could hear the landlady clattering up the stairs: "What the hell do you think you're doing? Trying to burn my house down?" And she threw him out first thing the next morning.

But now he was a man on a mission. Back into the dockyard, where he noticed a couple of ships in at the dock, laden with stores, packed with gunpowder. He smiled. Went into the hemp house to light the candle in the canister he'd left there the day before. But this time, his homemade matches wouldn't light. You know that feeling? Damp matches. Or the lighter that doesn't? So out of the dockyard he treks yet again, gets some new matches, and back again. Straight to the rope store. No messing this time.

As he makes his way out of town, he looks back towards Portsmouth,

where there's an orange glow on the horizon.

Was it arson or just an accident? The response had been quick, marines and sailors from the dockyard, citizens of Portsea, and only the rope store was lost, albeit all three hundred and fifty brick built yards of it.

A couple of men were arrested as they climbed out of one of the windows, but they'd been caught inside when the fire had started. A brief attempt was made to find and question the man seen in the dockyard the day before, John the Painter, but there was no real evidence it was arson, so they let the matter drop there.

Aitken tried again. Guards were set in Plymouth dockyard, but he had more success in Bristol, setting fire to several ships and warehouses there. But by now, the tin can device he had left in the hemp store in Portsmouth had been found and identified for what it was. And a description of John the Painter had been released.

In one of those strange quirks of fate, Aitken had been arrested the day before. For petty stealing. In the jail, he was recognised from his description and identified as John the Painter.

Under questioning in London, he was convinced the evidence against him was purely circumstantial. The case wasn't strong enough to prosecute him for high treason, and he was sure he could get off on the charge of arson. Which he might have done if he hadn't confided in another painter, a man who had also done a stint in America, about what he had done. If only that man hadn't been a spy.

In March 1777, James Aitken — then, as now, better known as John the Painter — was hanged on the Hard, from the tallest gallows Britain had ever seen, over 60 feet high, made from the mizen mast of a ship in the dock. It is said that twenty thousand people watched him execution, saw his body cut down then hung in chains on Blockhouse beach, where his body would be washed over by the tides each day. *(You can still see the iron cage in which his tarred body was hung in the small tower museum in Winchester to this day.)*

One newspaper report suggests that some time later — and gibbeted bodies could be on display for *years* — the head was stolen and hidden

in the chimney of a Gosport pub. But in the *story* I was told, the head was taken on tour, and shown around the various pubs of Gosport and Portsmouth for a penny a look.

Including at the Ship inn, down on the Hard, where Old Tom used to sit just in the back there, round the corner, by the fireside. Clay pipe in his mouth, stoppered glass bottle in his pocket. So the head turned up there, and it brought the punters in. Not that the Ship necessarily needed to put gigs like that on all the time, because the pub also had a good trade in letting out rooms by the hour to the officers of the ships in dock, so they could spend some time with their lady friends.

But then, one night, the head went missing.

And the rooms that were previously let by the hour were now abandoned after barely a minute or two thanks to the arrival of a rather unwelcoming ghost.

THE local priest was called, but it was beyond his pay grade. The Bishop was called, but he knew the reputation of the place. Then someone had the bright idea of asking Old Tom. He was well versed in capturing the wind, he knew the ways of the world, perhaps he could help.

“Well maybe I can, and maybe I can’t,” he said, “but I can have a damn good try. And I’ll want paying, mind, in beer and pies, for as long as it keeps away. But for now, I’ll need two or three things. An empty bottle, I have. A full bottle, I need. And an empty glass.” And when the landlord looked at him, not sure about what he meant, Tom pointed to the shelf behind the bar. “That bottle of rum should do it.”

Old Tom went up the stairs, taking a cork out of the empty bottle in his pocket as he did so.

Went into the room that was usually let for an hour, and closed the door behind him. And waited. Poured himself a tot of rum, and then another, and then a third. And as he was sat there, he felt the room get cold, felt something in the room beside him, saw a ghostly figure appear in front of him. And laughed — “you cabin boys up to your pranks, be gone with you.” And the ghost replied, “No. Old Tom, be

gone with YOU.” And Old Tom just sat there and poured himself another drink. He’d been to the Indies, and back, in his time; he’d been to the Americas, and back, in his time; and he’d seen a thing or too. And this was nothing to be afraid of. “So how did you get in then?” and he looked around the room. “Through the keyhole, I suppose? What nonsense. If you could get in through the keyhole, you should be able to get yourself into this bottle too...” and he placed the empty bottle from his pocket on the table. The ghost started to fade, to turn to a mist, and the cloud of smoke sucked its way into the bottle. Old Tom, quick as flash: the stopper in the bottle. Finished the rum. Made his way back down to the bar.

One of the landlord’s regular customers was offered the room for an hour, free of charge, to try it out. When he came down an hour later, and asked for second, the landlord knew the ghost had gone. Poured old Tom a pint. Asked him what pie he’d like.

For as long as that ghost stayed away, Tom continued to be paid in pints and pies, no longer needing to sell fair winds to the sailors. But it wasn’t long before either the pints or the pies got him, and he went to meet his maker. As to what happened to that last stoppered bottle, the story doesn’t say. But it does tell that in the months and years after his death, the ghost of Old Tom could still be seen, clay china pipe in his mouth and a stoppered bottle in his pocket, sitting in the corner, just round from the fire. And every so often he’d take the bottle out of his pocket, hold it up to the light, and he’d smile.